

AINI

STANDING TALL
Union home minister Amit Shah (centre) at a rally with Madhya Pradesh chief minister Mohan Yadav (left) and Union minister and BJP candidate Jyotiraditya Scindia in Guna, Apr. 26

endra Modi have joined our party in Madhya Pradesh. Earlier, we had just former parliamentarians and state legislators joining us, but of late, even sitting MLAs have quit the Congress."

For instance, just two days before the third phase of polling on May 7, Congress MLA Nirmala Sapre from the Bina assembly segment in Sagar constituency joined the BJP at a rally led by Chief Minister Mohan Yadav, thus becoming the third Congress legislator to make the switch since late March. Earlier, on April 30, veteran Congress leader Ramniwas Rawat, who is the incumbent MLA from Sheopur district's Vijaypur seat, had also entered the saffron fold. A month before that, the BJP had managed to rope in three-time Congress MLA Kamlesh Shah, who represents the Amarwara assembly seat in the Chhindwara parliamentary constituency.

The defections are not just for the sake of political one-upmanship; there is a carefully thought-out strategy behind them. In 2019, the BJP had won all but one seat—Chhindwara, the bastion of former chief minister Kamal Nath that is currently being represented by his son Nakul. This makes this parliamentary seat, which went to the polls in the first phase on April 19, a prestige battle for both the BJP and the Congress. So it came as no surprise when, besides Kamlesh Shah, a large number of Congress corporators and block-level leaders from rural areas quit the party to join the BJP in the run up to the election. Even Chhindwara mayor Vikram Ahake had made a switch to the BJP before taking a U-turn and return-

THE LION'S SHARE

After an upset in the 2018 assembly polls, the BJP has reclaimed its turf in Madhya Pradesh

